

Problem Statement: "Court Navigator" — A Procedural Guidance Tool for Self-Representing Litigants and Advocates

1. Background — Why This Problem Matters

India has roughly 20+ lakh registered advocates and lakhs more law students, but the number of people who interact with courts without full procedural knowledge is far larger. This includes:

Party-in-person litigants (people who represent themselves under Order III / Section 32 CPC or as accused persons), who have a legal right to appear but rarely understand how a courtroom actually runs.

Young/newly enrolled advocates who know substantive law from law school but were never formally taught courtroom procedure, filing etiquette, or "what document goes with what application."

Litigants represented by advocates who still don't understand what is happening in their own case, leading to anxiety, missed deadlines, and repeated visits to courts.

The result of this knowledge gap is well known inside courtrooms:

Matters get adjourned or delayed because the correct application, affidavit, or annexure wasn't filed in the correct format.

Judges get visibly frustrated ("angry") at parties-in-person or junior advocates who don't know basic courtroom etiquette (how to address the court, when to stand, how to seek permission to argue, how to mention a matter, how to file for urgent listing, etc.).

People don't know the difference in procedure between a District Court, a High Court, and the Supreme Court e.g., what a "cause list" is, what "PIL," "SLP," "caveat," "vakalatnama," "interim application," "written statement," "counter affidavit," "rejoinder," "stay," "ex-parte," "in-limine," "listing before the Registrar," etc. actually mean and when each is used.

This unequal access to procedural knowledge (as opposed to substantive law) creates a genuine access-to-justice problem — the law may give someone a right, but they can't effectively exercise it because they don't know the process.

2. The Core Problem Statement (one paragraph, for the developer)

Build a tool that helps a common person or a self-representing party (and even a newly practicing advocate) understand Indian court procedure end-to-end what to file, in what format, at what stage, in what court (District/High Court/Supreme Court), what courtroom etiquette and terminology to follow, and what happens next in their case so that they can

represent themselves (or interact with the court process) confidently, without confusion, and without causing delay through procedural mistakes.

This is not a tool for giving legal advice on the merits of a case (i.e., it should not tell someone whether they will "win" or what argument to make). It is a procedural navigation and legal-literacy tool the "how do courts work" layer, not the "what is the law" layer.

3. Who Are We Building This For (User Personas)

Persona

Problem they face

Party-in-person (litigant with no lawyer) = Doesn't know what documents to file, doesn't know court language/etiquette, gets scolded by judges, doesn't know next steps after each hearing

First-time/junior advocate = Knows the law but not the procedure drafting formats, stamp/court-fee requirements, e-filing steps, how to mention urgent matters

Law student / paralegal volunteer = Wants a reference tool to guide clients at legal aid clinics

General literate citizen = Received a court notice/summons and doesn't understand what it means or what to do next

4. Scope: Which Courts and Which Procedures

The tool should cover procedure at three tiers of the Indian judiciary, since each has different rules and terminology:

District Courts / Trial Courts (Civil & Criminal) e.g., CPC procedure (plaint, written statement, issues, evidence, arguments, judgment), CrPC/BNSS procedure (FIR, chargesheet, bail application, framing of charges, trial stages)

High Courts — Writ petitions, appeals, revisions, PILs, bail under Section 439/483, format of vakalatnama, e-filing portal steps

Supreme Court — SLPs, appeals, PILs under Article 32, caveat filing, registry objections, how listing before a bench works

For each tier, the tool should be able to answer: "I am at [stage X] in [court type Y] for [case type Z] — what do I need to do, what should I file, and how should I conduct myself?"

5. Core Features to Build

A. Procedure Explainer / Step-by-Step Case Journey

A guided flow where the user selects: court type → case type (civil/criminal/writ/appeal) → current stage. The tool then shows a plain-language, sequential explanation of what happens next, in the correct order (e.g., filing → notice → appearance → written statement → framing of issues → evidence → arguments → judgment).

B. Document Checklist Generator

For any given stage/application (e.g., "filing an interim injunction," "filing a bail application," "filing a first appeal"), generate the exact list of documents/annexures required (affidavit, vakalatnama, court-fee stamp, index, memo of parties, proof of service, etc.), based on real procedural rules.

C. Legal & Procedural Glossary (Plain-Language)

A searchable glossary translating court jargon into simple language e.g., "caveat," "ex-parte," "in-limine," "suo motu," "locus standi," "interlocutory application," "stay order," "cause list," "mentioning" each explained in one or two plain sentences, ideally in Hindi + English (and other regional languages if time permits), since many self-representing litigants are more comfortable in Hindi.

D. Courtroom Etiquette & Conduct Guide

Practical guidance most people never get taught: how to address a judge ("My Lord"/"Your Honour"/"Sir" as per current practice), when to stand, how to seek the court's permission before speaking, how to hand up documents, how to behave when a matter is called, dress code norms, and common mistakes to avoid that lead to judicial irritation or adjournment.

E. "What Just Happened" Decoder

User uploads or types in an order/notice they received (or a short description of what the judge said), and the tool explains in plain language what it means and what the recommended next step is (e.g., "your matter was 'adjourned sine die' this means...").

F. (Optional/Stretch) AI Assistant Chat Layer

A conversational interface where the user can ask free-form questions ("I got a summons from a district court, what do I do?") and the tool responds using the structured procedural knowledge base above not as case-specific legal advice, but as procedural guidance, with a clear disclaimer to consult a lawyer for advice on the merits.

6. Non-Functional Requirements / Constraints

Accuracy over cleverness: Procedural information must be sourced from actual CPC, CrPC/BNSS, Supreme Court Rules, High Court Rules, and e-filing manuals not invented. Where a rule varies by state/High Court, flag that clearly rather than presenting one rule as universal.

No legal advice on merits: The tool must be explicitly scoped to procedure, not case outcome prediction or legal strategy this avoids both harm to users and unauthorized-practice-of-law concerns.

Accessibility: Simple language, works for low digital literacy users, ideally bilingual (Hindi/English), and usable on low-end phones/slow internet.

Coding knowledge not required from the team per hackathon rules, the emphasis is on describing the problem and desired behavior clearly (vibe-coding), which this document is meant to support.

7. What Success Looks Like

A self-representing litigant (or junior advocate) should be able to open the tool, select their court and case stage, and within a few minutes know: what document to prepare, in what format, what to say/do in the courtroom, and what typically happens next reducing procedural mistakes, adjournments, and friction with the court, and giving them a genuinely equal opportunity to be heard.

8. Suggested Next Step for the Developer

Start with one narrow slice end-to-end (e.g., "Filing a bail application in a District Court") build the full user journey (procedure explainer → document checklist → glossary terms used → etiquette tips) for that single scenario first, validate it's accurate and genuinely useful, then expand to more case types and court tiers.